WELCOME TO SOC 361: Historical Development of Sociological Theory

SUMMER SESSION I, 2025 (ends July 3, 2025)

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Office hours: Zoom, by appointment
SBC: SBS+, WRTD

Course Description

In this course we study the historical development of sociological theory. In the first half of the course, we familiarize ourselves with the undisputed sociological canon: Marx, Weber, Durkheim, and their respective analytical traditions. In the second half, we explore how theorists from contemporary sociological angles such as feminism, critical race and disability theories, and technology studies have attempted to overcome the many limitations of the canon. This course necessarily concerns itself with topics in the philosophy of science, and special emphasis will be given to the methodological assumptions that lie at the heart of theories of society. In other words: what are the appropriate ways to understand social reality? We refer to this question throughout the course as we explore topics such as structuralism, conflict theory, and feminism by reading some of history's most influential theories.

Expected Learning Outcomes

You will learn how to:

- Use sociological theories to better understand your own social reality
- Identify the relationship between contemporary and classical theory
- Discuss sociology with reference to its key concepts and theoretical perspectives

Course Materials and Lectures

Readings: Weekly readings will be posted on Brightspace each Monday. These readings will mostly be related to the lectures, but the lectures will not cover everything in the readings. It is recommended to watch the lecture first, as this will prepare you to understand the materials more easily. Some of these readings will be very challenging. The purpose of my lectures is to make them more easily digestible for you.

Lectures: Each week there will be two lectures. Lectures will be posted on Monday. All lectures are in the form of video-essays produced by your professor and hosted on youtube.

Assignments

Your final grade will be based on a combination of written engagement with sociological theories and two exams. You may not use AI to write any of the required coursework. However, you may find it a valuable resource for helping you understand and interpret some of these readings.

- **Weekly reflections:** Each week you will submit a 350-word reflection. You should include references to at least one of the readings assigned that week. You may also reference previous weeks if you wish. In this reflection, you will discuss the readings and lectures with reference to the weekly discussion prompt. The discussion prompt might be a question, a news article, a video, or some other form of media. Prompts will be posted on Mondays. The purpose of this assignment is to check your reading comprehension. Weekly reflections are due on Brightspace every Monday by 11:59 PM. This will be the primary way you will be evaluated on your understanding of readings that are not covered during the weekly lectures.
- **Final paper:** The course will culminate in a ten-page (double-spaced) final paper in which you will be required to explore a social problem of your choice via the application of one or more of the theoretical approaches covered this semester. The paper will be written in ASA format and will be submitted on Brightspace before 11:59 PM on the last day of class. In this paper you are expected to do the following:
    1. Introduce a social problem of your choice. Provide a brief background of the problem and explain why it is a social problem rather than a personal problem. The difference between social and personal problems should be abundantly clear to you by the time you propose your essay.
    2. Summarize the theoretical perspective(s) of your choice. Clearly state the concepts you will be using and explain why they are suitable to analyze the problem.
    3. Use the theory to imagine a path to a better world. In an ideal world, what needs to happen socially and culturally to address this problem? What can be done now to make this happen?
    4. There is no requirement for the number of citations, but you should use outside citations as necessary, especially when detailing your chosen social problem. You should cite at least one of the theorists that we have covered this semester—more is not necessarily better.

    Your paper should have a clear introduction which poses the social problem and conclusion which summarizes your argument. You will be evaluated primarily on the clarity of your argument and the accuracy and creativity you demonstrate when applying your chosen theoretical perspective(s).
- **Exams:** The exams will be multiple choice. All exams are cumulative and based only on lecture content.

Grading Structure

Assignment	Weight
Exam 1 (online, synchronous, 2 hours, June 12)	15%
Exam 2 (online, synchronous, 2 hours, July 3)	20%
Weekly reflections	25%
Final paper (July 3)	40%

Grade Range	Outcome
93-100	A
90-92	A-
87-89	B+
83-86	B
80-82	B-
77-79	C+
73-76	C
70-72	C-
67-69	D+
63-66	D
< 63	F

Course Schedule and Readings

Class	Topic	Watch / Read	Deadlines (11:59 PM on Brightspace)
1	Enlightenment Theories of Knowledge	**Watch:** Sociology: Auguste Comte; David Hume's Theory of Knowledge **Read:** Kant, "Answer to the Question: What Is Enlightenment?"	
2	Weber and Antipositivism	**Watch:** Rationalisation **Read:** Weber, *The Protestant Ethic and the Spirit of Capitalism*; Walker, "Weber: Antipositivism & Verstehen"	
3	Durkheim and Structural Functionalism	**Watch:** Émile Durkheim on Suicide & Society (Crash Course Sociology #5) **Read:** Durkheim, "The Social Element of Suicide"; Davis & Moore, "Some Principles of Stratification"	
4	Early Marxism	**Watch:** Karl Marx: What Is Primitive Accumulation? **Read:** Marx & Engels, "Manifesto of the Communist Party"; Gramsci, *Selections from the Prison Notebooks*	
5	The Frankfurt School	**Watch:** What Is Critical Theory? (The Frankfurt School) **Read:** Adorno, "The Culture Industry: Enlightenment as Mass Deception"; Habermas, *Legitimation Crisis*	
6	Exam 1	—	Exam 1: Thursday, June 12 (Online, 2-hour limit)
7	Georg Simmel	**Watch:** Georg Simmel: Interaction, Social Types, Social Forms **Read:** Simmel, "The Metropolis and Mental Life"; Simmel, "The Stranger"	
8	Elite Theory	**Read:** Mills, *The Power Elite* (Ch. 1: The Higher Circles); Mills & Domhoff, "The Policy-Planning Capacity of the American Corporate Community"	
9	Race and Intersectionality	**Watch:** What Is Intersectionality? (Queer 101, The Advocate) **Read:** Crenshaw, "Mapping the Margins: Intersectionality, Identity Politics, and Violence against Women of Color"; Du Bois, *The Souls of Black Folk* (Forethought and Ch. 1, pp. 3-14)	

10	Feminism (and Beyond)	**Watch:** *The Second Sex* by Simone de Beauvoir: Summary and Analysis **Read:** de Beauvoir, *The Second Sex* (Introduction: Woman as Other); Haraway, "A Cyborg Manifesto"	
11	Network Studies	**Read:** Latour, *Reassembling the Social* (pp. 63-87); Granovetter, "The Strength of Weak Ties"; Lazer, "Data ex Machina: Introduction to Big Data"; Shirky, *Extreme Democracy* (Ch. 3, additional reading)	
12	Exam 2	—	Exam 2: Thursday, July 3 (Online, 2-hour limit) Final Paper: Due Thursday, July 3

Course Policies

Late policy: Let your instructor know immediately if you will submit work late, including the weekly reflections and final paper. Each student is permitted to turn in up to two assignments late at no penalty. After this, you will receive a 25% point deduction per day. Assignments submitted more than 48 hours late will not be accepted. Considerations will be made for students with accessibility challenges.

Exam policy: All missed exams must promptly be taken with instructor approval during office hours within two weeks. Please contact the instructor before the day of the exam in the event that you will not be able to take it on time. In the event that you must miss an exam, you must receive pre-approval from the instructor or submit proof of extenuating circumstances. Whenever possible, you should let the instructor know in advance if you will miss an exam.

Stony Brook University Policies

- **Student Accessibility Support Center:** If you have a physical, psychological, medical, or learning disability that may impact your course work, please contact the Student Accessibility Support Center, Stony Brook Union Suite 107, (631) 632-6748, or at sasc@stonybrook.edu. They will determine with you what accommodations are necessary and appropriate. All information and documentation is confidential.
- **Academic Integrity Statement:** Each student must pursue his or her academic goals honestly and be personally accountable for all submitted work. Representing another person's work as your own is always wrong. Faculty is required to report any suspected instances of academic dishonesty to the Academic Judiciary. Faculty in the Health Sciences Center (School of Health Professions, Nursing, Social Welfare, Dental Medicine) and School of Medicine are required to follow their school-specific procedures. For more comprehensive information on academic integrity, including categories of academic dishonesty, please refer to the Academic Judiciary website.

- **Critical Incident Management:** Stony Brook University expects students to respect the rights, privileges, and property of other people. Faculty are required to report to the Office of Student Conduct and Community Standards any disruptive behavior that interrupts their ability to teach, compromises the safety of the learning environment, or inhibits students' ability to learn. Faculty in the HSC Schools and the School of Medicine are required to follow their school-specific procedures. Further information about most academic matters can be found in the Undergraduate Bulletin, the Undergraduate Class Schedule, and the Faculty-Employee Handbook.